

Asking your manager for a raise

6 findings · 12-step checklist · 2 myths · 5 sources · cheatgrid.com

Asking carries a real cost however calmly you do it, and aiming at a **high, ambitious number** still beats aiming modest. Playing it safe costs you money.

THE GOAL

You want a specific number on the table and a real answer to it. State your exact number in one clear sentence, before they offer anything.

CHECKLIST

You're sitting with your manager, about to ask for a raise.

- ☐ Confirm you won't be interrupted, door closed or otherwise, before you start talking.
- ☐ Check that your number is written down somewhere you can see it.
- ☐ Say in one sentence that you want to talk about your pay.
- ☐ State your **exact number** in one clear sentence, rather than waiting to see what they offer first.
- ☐ Name something the raise would let you do better for the team, out loud.
- ☐ If they don't respond right away, wait for them to speak next instead of filling the gap yourself.
- ☐ If they counter with a lower number, restate your figure once, evenly, rather than moving to meet them straight away.
- ☐ If they say yes, ask when the change takes effect and get that **in writing** before you leave.
- ☐ If they need time to decide, agree on a specific date you'll hear back, right there in the room.
- ☐ If they say no, ask what specifically would need to be different for the answer to change.
- ☐ Write down what was actually said, the number, the date, or the reason for no, before you leave the room.
- ☐ Thank them for the conversation before you leave, **regardless of the answer**.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1 Negotiating for more money carries a real cost, however calmly you do it. Evaluators **judge you more harshly** for asking, and much harder if you're a woman.
- 2 A strong outcome can cost you the goodwill of the person who gave it to you. People who lose more to a high-aiming counterpart end up **far less willing to help them again**.
- 3 Aiming for a **high, ambitious number** gets you a better outcome than aiming modest. Playing it safe costs you money.

What asking actually costs you

KNOW

Negotiating for more money carries a real cost, however calmly you do it. Evaluators **judge you more harshly** for asking, and much harder if you're a woman.

In lab tests, evaluators penalized a woman who had negotiated far more than an identical man who had. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

A strong outcome can cost you the goodwill of the person who gave it to you. People who lose more to a high-aiming counterpart end up **far less willing to help them again**.

Sellers who'd lost more to a high-aiming buyer split a later prize evenly with them far less often than sellers who'd faced a lower-aiming buyer. [Source 2](#)

KNOW

If you're a woman, a no **isn't proof you failed**. Women ask as often as men, and get fewer yeses.

The measured gap was in who got a yes, not in who was willing to ask. [Source 3](#)

Making the ask land

DO

Aiming for a **high, ambitious number** gets you a better outcome than aiming modest. Playing it safe costs you money.

Buyers who set a high target price negotiated significantly better deals than buyers who aimed lower did. [Source 2](#)

SAY

If you're a woman, pair your number with a reason that shows you still care about the working relationship, not just the number. That kind of reason raised both the offer and how you were seen.

Giving that kind of reason raised both likability and the offer, but only for women who used it. [Source 4](#)

KNOW

Being warm about it makes people want to work with you, but it **doesn't raise your pay**.

Showing concern for the relationship alone raised how a negotiator was liked, but not the salary offered to them. [Source 4](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

Staying completely silent after you name your number is a power move that will make your manager cave and give you more.

ACTUALLY

That trick was tested in exactly this setup, someone lower in the room going quiet on someone above them, and it **didn't work**. The person who went quiet felt worse, and nobody did better for it. [Source 5](#)

MYTH

The reason women end up paid less is that they don't ask for raises as often as men do.

ACTUALLY

A large matched employer-employee survey tested this directly and found no real difference in how often men and women ask. Women ask about as often; **they just come away with the raise less often**. [Source 3](#)

Sources

1. <https://gap.hks.harvard.edu/social-incentives-gender-differences-propensity-initiate-negotiations-sometimes-it-does-hurt-ask>
2. <https://www.pon.harvard.edu/daily/negotiation-skills-daily/how-to-avoid-the-negative-impact-of-goal-setting-setting-realistic-objectives-in-negotiations/>
3. https://onlabor.org/wp-content/uploads/2016/09/twerp_1127_oswald.pdf
4. <https://gap.hks.harvard.edu/how-can-women-escape-compensation-negotiation-dilemma-relational-accounts-are-one-answer>
5. <https://mitsloan.mit.edu/ideas-made-to-matter/negotiation-use-silence-to-improve-outcomes-all>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Asking for money at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

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